trump card for re-election in 2024. The MOTN results show that while Mamata Banerjee, Arvind Kejriwal and Rahul Gandhi—in that order—are seen as best suited to lead an Opposition alliance, their popular appeal lags way behind Modi's. That's because the Opposition has so far been unable to build a convincing narrative against the Modi government's performance, or to give the electorate a cohesive, alternative vision of governance. In fact, the survey shows that Modi is now considered by far the best prime minister India has had, way ahead of Indira Gandhi, Atal Bihari Vajpayee or Jawaharlal Nehru.

Interestingly, when asked who is best suited to succeed Modi as the BJP's prime ministerial candidate, the survey, for the first time, throws up a dead heat between the Union home minister Amit Shah and Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath. The gap had started narrowing in the previous MOTN. If the BJP wins the upcoming poll in UP, then the scales may tilt further in favour of Adityanath. The UP chief minister's rise may be because he is seen as more of a Hindutva hardliner—much as Modi was prior to 2014. It was in the run-up to 2014 that Modi overtook L.K. Advani as the most prominent hardliner and emerged as the prime BJP contender for the post of prime minister.

While these may be battles of perception, there is little doubt that the Modi-Shah duo cemented its Hindutva credentials at the beginning of the NDA's second term. They moved swiftly to dilute Article 370 (a move in which Shah took the lead) and, after the Supreme Court verdict in the Ayodhya dispute ruling in favour of building a Ram temple in Ayodhya, put its construction on the fast track. Both these actions continue to be regarded as the Modi government's top achievements, ensuring that the BJP retains its core Hindutva vote.

Overall, the MOTN results are a mixed bag for Modi and his government.

Q. WHO HAS BEEN INDIA'S BEST PRIME MINISTER SO FAR?

Narendra Modi 34%


Atal Bihari Vajpayee **20.3%**


Indira Gandhi **10.8%**


Jawaharlal Nehru **8.8%**


Manmohan Singh **6.8%**


Lal Bahadur Shastri **5%**


V.P. Singh **4.5%**


Rajiv Gandhi **2.6%**


P.V. Narasimha Rao **1.8%**


Morarji Desai **1.4%**

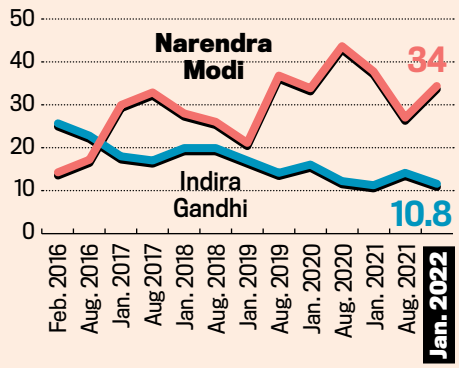
Note: Rest DK/ CS (Don't know/ can't say) and Others



NARENDRA MODI VS. INDIRA GANDHI



How the MOTN surveys reflected the popularity trends of two Indian prime ministers known for radical moves



NARENDRA MODI VS. RAHUL GANDHI



How the MOTN surveys have captured public mood on the choice of prime ministerial candidate between the leaders of the two national parties

